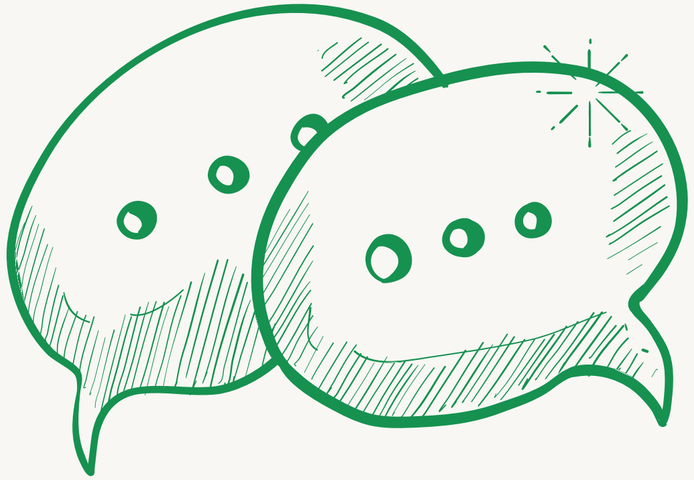
COMMUNICATION

The "Nodding Head" Disaster

Passive vs Active Listening & EQ



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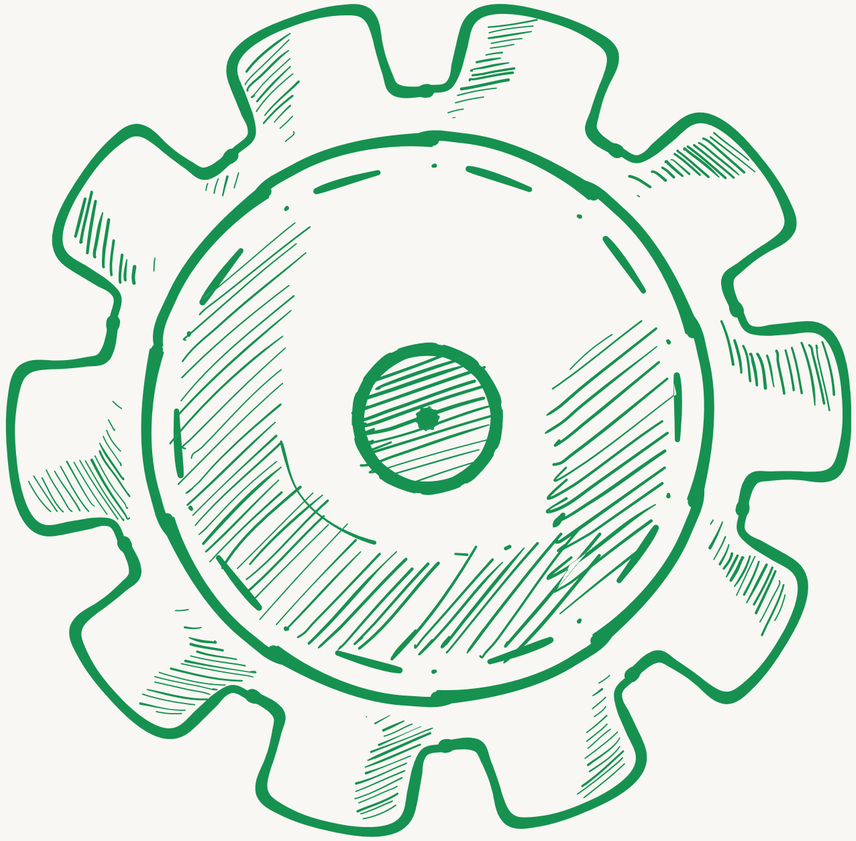
BACKGROUND

Comapny: Build IT
Situation: Tight Deadline
Issue: Ignored soil report warnings
Result: $2M Loss

"People often listen with the intent to respond rather than the intent to understand. This means that they are relying more on hearing than listening,"

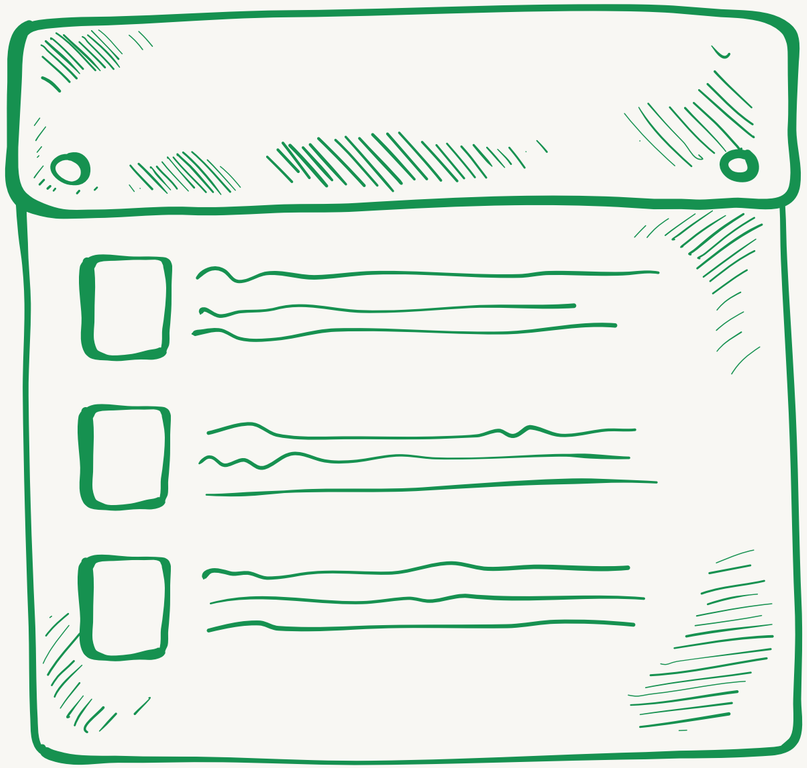


CORE PROBLEM

- Sarah heard but didn’t listen
- No clarification
- Ignored emotional cues
- Focused only on timeline & budget

KEY CONCEPTS TO DELIVER

- Hearing vs Listening
- Selective Perception
- Emotional Intelligence (EQ)
- Paraphrasing



HEARNING VS LISTENING

Have you ever found yourself losing focus mid-convo? You keep nodding your head, but you're not absorbing a single word the other person is saying. That's the difference between hearing and listening.

Hearing is just receiving sound, but listening is understanding and responding to it.

HEARNING VS LISTENING

LISTENING VERSUS HEARING	
Hearing is passive	Listening is active
Refers to the act of perceiving a sound through the ear	Refers to the act of making a conscious effort to perceive the sound
Does not require a conscious effort	Requires a conscious effort
Involuntary	Voluntary

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HEARNING VS LISTENING

Hearing: Sarah hears “soil reports are inconsistent” and moves on

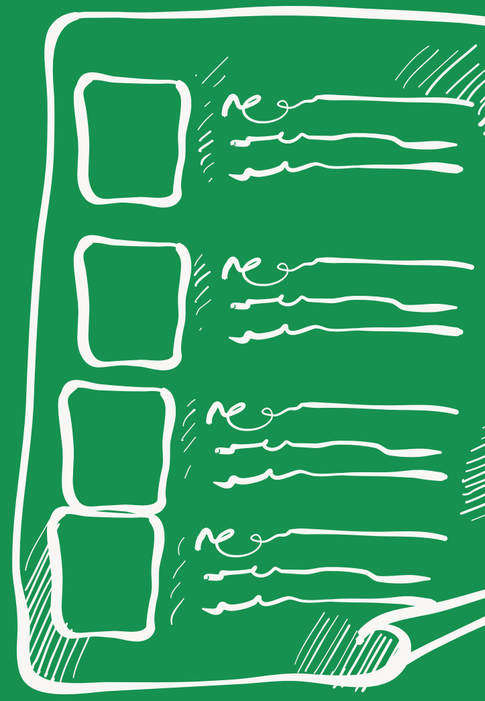
Listening: Sarah understands “this could cause foundation failure” and takes action

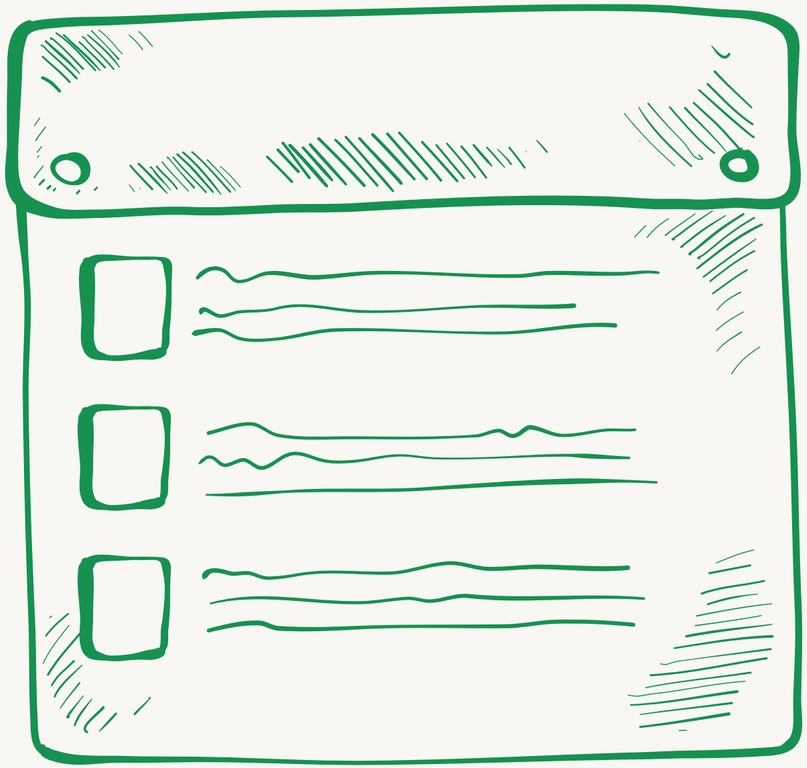
SELECTIVE PERCEPTION

Selective perception is focusing only on what we want to hear and ignoring other important information.

What Happened in This Case

- Sarah focused only on:
  - Budget
  - Timeline
- Ignored:
  - Risk in soil reports
  - Engineer’s concern



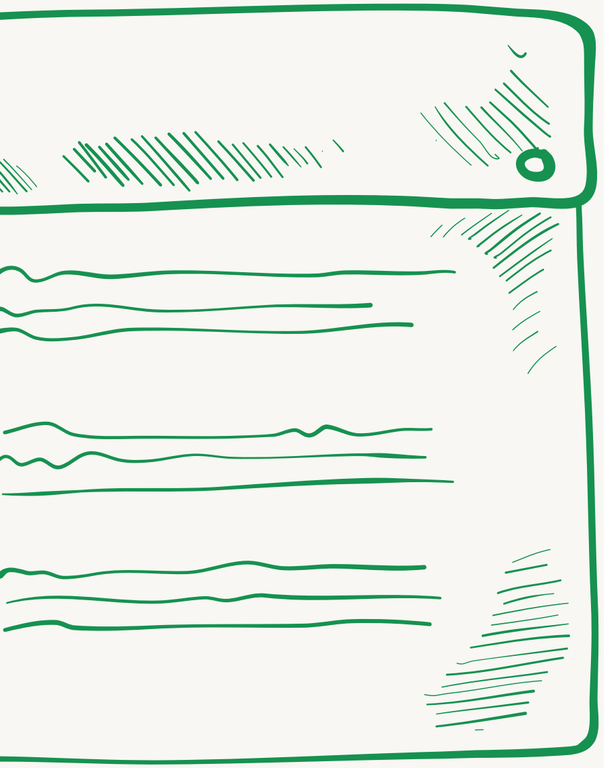


EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE (IQ)

Emotional Intelligence is the ability to understand and manage your own emotions and others' emotions."

What Happened in This Case

- Sarah ignored:
  - Engineer's worried tone
  - Signs of concern
- Showed:
  - No empathy
  - No emotional awareness



EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE (IQ)

Emotional intelligence and communication don’t always come together in the workplace. But when they do, leaders and their teams reap significant benefits.

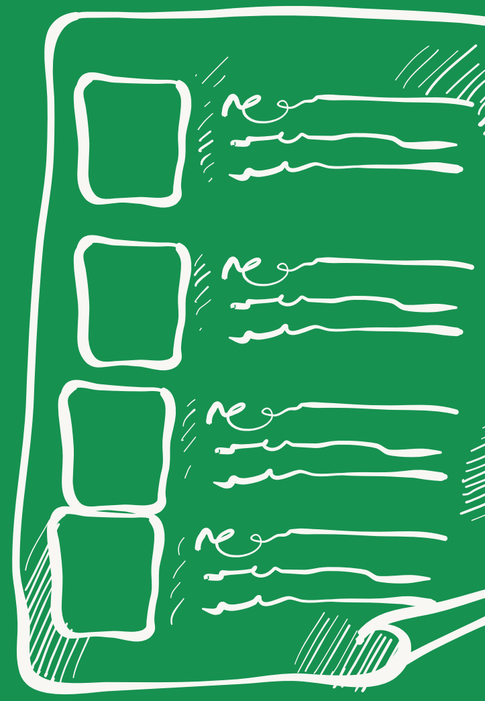
- Like a Tool to enhance Communication
- Helps in building mutual respect and understanding
- A quality that is needed to be a great leader

PARAPHRASING

Paraphrasing means repeating what someone said in your own words to confirm understanding."

What Happened in This Case

- Sarah did NOT paraphrase
- She just said: "Got it"
- This led to misunderstanding and ignored risk

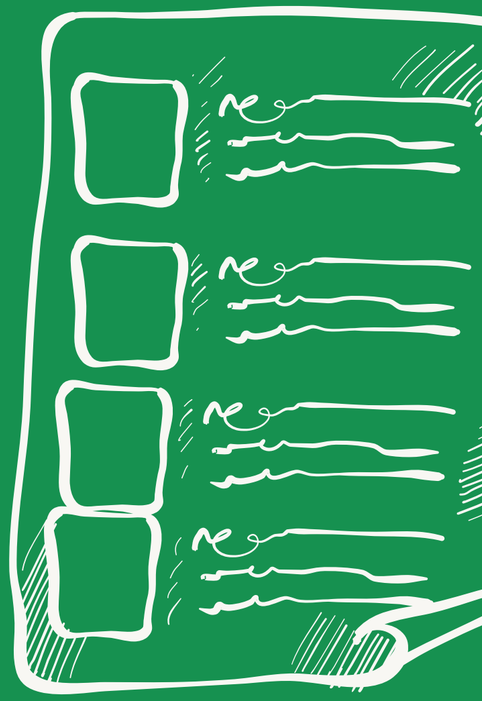


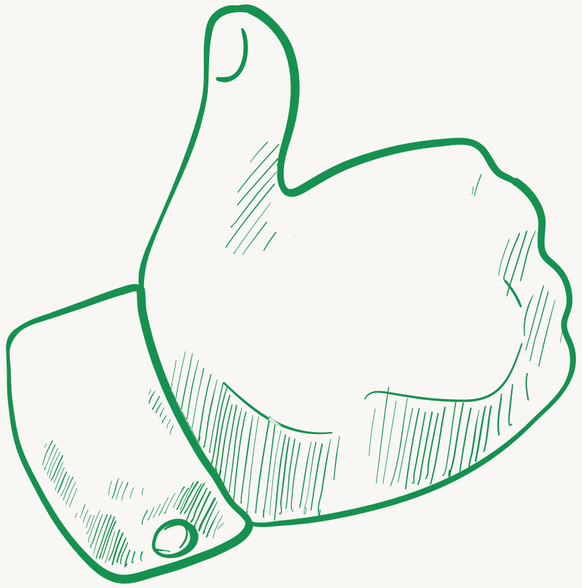
PARAPHRASING

It’s something we see in our work and tasks.

As, we research using AI agents and LLMs which we later try to paraphrase in our own human words or human way.

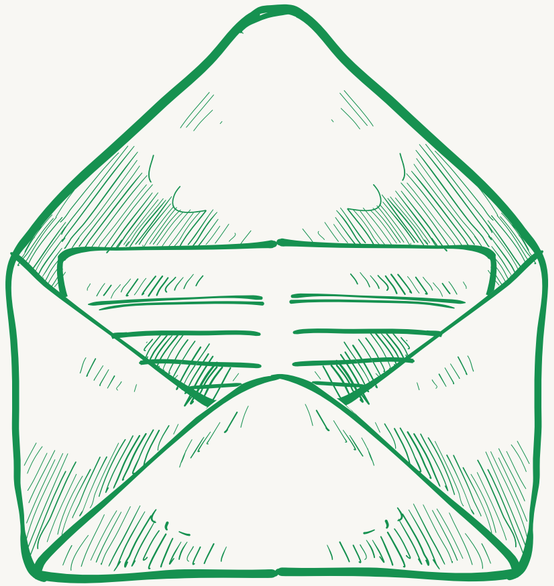
It also shows that we didn’t just copy paste the entire content but took inspiration or knowledge and portrayed in our own nature.





ANALYSIS

- Communication failure
- No active listening
- Lack of empathy
- Decision bias



ANALYSIS

What actually went wrong?

- Sarah failed to recognize the engineer's concern and urgency
- Ignored emotional cues like:
  - Worried tone
  - Repeated warnings

ANALYSIS

Impact on Leadership

- Created a gap between manager and team
- Reduced trust and collaboration
- Led to poor decision-making

How It Affected Communication

- No deeper discussion happened
- Engineer’s message was not taken seriously
- Important risk remained hidden

SOLUTIONS

- Active listening techniques
- Ask questions
- Paraphrase
- Pay attention to tone/emotion

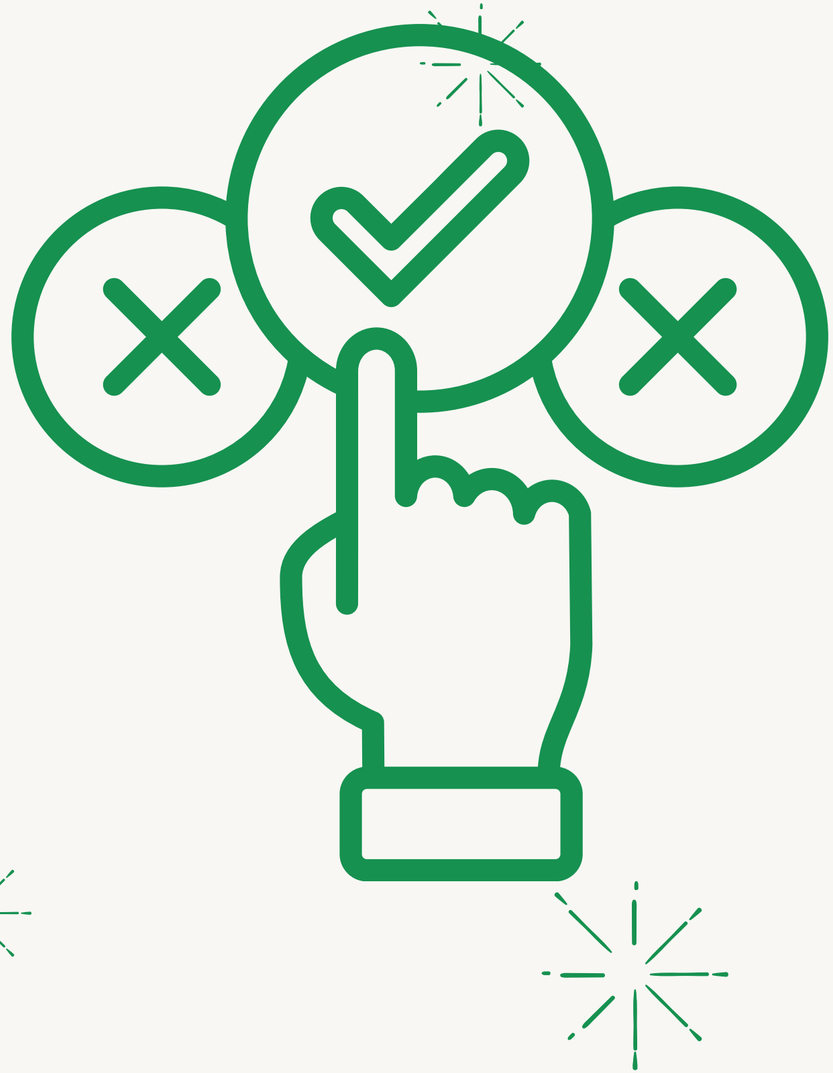
WHAT SHOULD HAVE SARAH DONE?

Active Listening in Action

- Stop rushing the meeting
- Pay full attention to the engineer
- Notice tone and concern

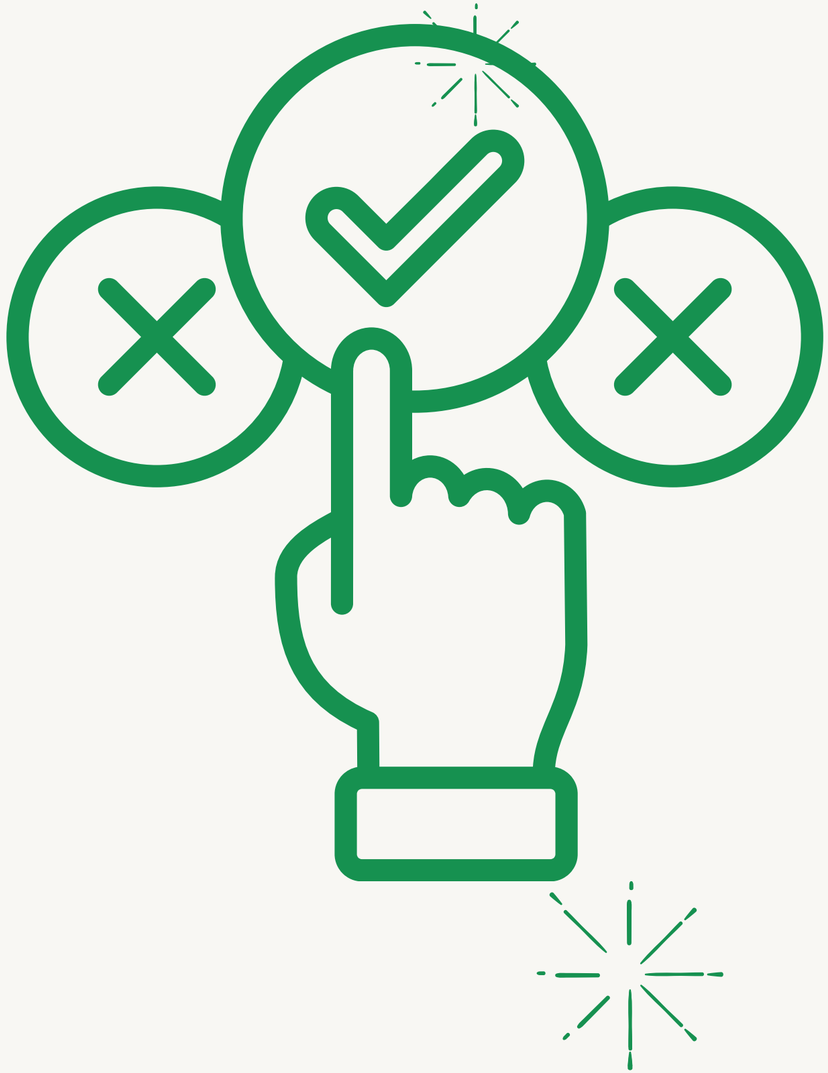
Ask Clarifying Questions

- “Can you explain what you mean by inconsistent?”
- “How serious is this issue?”
- “What could happen if we ignore this?”



“So you're concerned that the soil may not be stable enough. How risky is this?”

WHAT SHOULD HAVE SARAH DONE?



Use Paraphrasing (Very Important)

- “So, what you're saying is the soil might not support the structure properly?”
- “This could affect the foundation stability, right?”

Take Immediate Action

- Pause construction decisions
- Request detailed soil testing
- Involve experts if needed

“Example : So you're concerned that the soil may not be stable enough. How risky is this?”

KEY LESSON LEARNED

- Hearing is not enough — active listening is essential
- Ignoring small concerns can lead to major failures
- Communication is as important as technical skills

The saying ‘In one ear, out the other’ speaks to the difference between hearing and listening.

— Kelly Workman, PsyD

TIPS TO BECOME A BETTER LISTENER

- Cultivate the right mindset
- Practice Present and Mindful Listening
- Stay Actively Engaged in Conversations
- Listen Deeply
- Try to use some little body language
- Give advice only if required

CONCLUSION

"This case shows that failure was caused not by lack of data, but by lack of proper listening and understanding."

What This Case Teaches Us

- Always:
  - Listen actively
  - Ask questions
  - Paraphrase to confirm understanding
  - Pay attention to emotions (EQ)

Real-World Impact

- Poor communication → $2 million loss
- Effective communication → Better decisions, safety, and success

THANK YOU

queries?